Asiatic Steam Navigation Company also serviced Tuticorin with Volkart Bros acting as their Agents. A Japanese liner also called regularly.

How was this global enterprise managed and who conducted its business in far-off Tuticorin?

Mackinnon, Mackenzie and Company, Calcutta was the Managing Agents of BI.[45] The Managing Agency system was a curious feature of business entrepreneurship in colonial India where professional managers ran the company even without owning a majority of shares.[46] Managing Agents, usually a firm, had absolute control as long as they delivered high dividends to the shareholders. As one of its unabashed champions put it, 'the Managing Agency system supplied the necessary technical, financial and administrative skills where Indians desiring to develop their country's industries by the formation of Companies supplied the necessary funds; this it might do for a fee or in return for shares in the Company to be formed and managed.'[47]

BI paid a dividend of 10 to 15 per cent consistently during this period.[48] Besides this, between 1882 and 1893, the profits of Mackinnon, Mackenzie and Company averaged 28.5 per cent per annum, and its capital swelled from Rs 35–67 lakh.[49] Between 1901 and 1925 it still declared a substantial annual profit of 22 per cent.[50] The huge profits it earned were based on its control of BI. By the beginning of the twentieth century, when VOC took on the might of BI, the company possessed the largest number of steamers (over a hundred) in the world with an aggregate tonnage of over 6,50,000.[51]

It was hardly feasible or practical to manage the business from its registered office in London or its operational headquarters in Calcutta. As the official chronicler of BI described it, 'sound agencies were being built up in all principal ports' for this purpose.[52] Firms or registered companies who held a variety of interests in the ports were appointed as Agents. An extensive network of Agents and Sub-Agents was built to nurture BI's interests and to service its customers. 'The principal agencies became largely extensions of the head office [in Calcutta] managed and manned by experienced persons who had come through the mill in Calcutta.'[53]